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another concept that has not been fully studied in recent years has been the one with which it may be coupled – expertise – and we will turn to this shortly. However, we have to recognise that not all become wise as a result of living because there are many times when we fail to learn from our experiences – we presume upon them and take them for granted. Non-learning from experience is something quite vital to our understanding of learning (Jarvis, 1987), although there may be tacit changes in our understanding of ourselves as a result of this process.

Part 3: Experience as episode/event

In my previous work I did not separate these two terms. Following Donald (2001), I now think that this was a serious mistake, and much of my work has been based on events, which I called episodes, although episodes are actually series of events bound together in conscious awareness of their unity. It is, however, a major flaw in those evolutionary psychologists who consider that the brain is hard-wired as a result of our evolution and that we are programmed by our past to respond to stimuli in specific ways and at specific times. Donald argues that this flaw is exhibited by some of those scholars who believe that they are constructing a science of learning (OECD, 2007b: 11) and consider that our brains are fully wired at birth: scientists can claim that our brains are hard-wired based upon experiments that are no longer than a single event but not for those which span a whole episode, or sequence of events. Laboratory experiments can be carefully designed to record the here and now – they study sensations and very short-term memory – but these are not the limits of consciousness: this has ‘a much larger window of experience than short-term memory’ (Donald, 2001: 47). We can have an experience of a whole class or even a whole course – experience is an episode in our lives. The capacity of our brains is much larger than that required for the consciousness of a single sensation. We continue to be aware of the situation for a much longer period of time than the immediate and we hold it in our working memory for as long as necessary. No brain can be programmed to respond to a whole episode and this undermines a great deal of the theory of the hard-wired brain. It is what Schutz and Luckmann (1974: 51) called ‘a stream of consciousness’: experience is a sequence of events that overlap and form a continuous whole and yet, like biography, it is a single episode in our lives.

We sometimes live in the flow of time, an episode in which we seem to have heightened awareness all the time – what Csikszentmihalyi (1990) calls optimal experience – our awareness enables us to learn rapidly and effortlessly without interruption. He (ibid.: 39) describes this as when ‘information that keeps coming into awareness is congruent with goals’ that leads to psychic energy flowing effortlessly. An interruption to this flow can occur – a disruptive disjuncture – which can refocus our attention on a different event. When I started my own research into learning I was interested in a sense of ‘feeling at home’ in our own life-world upon which we can presume in an almost unthinking manner – a process which Bergson (1999 [1965]) called *durée*. We take the world for granted and, as it were, act in an ‘almost mindless manner’ but suddenly something occurs which we can no longer take for granted and we experience a degree of disjuncture: we have a heightened consciousness or awareness and we are forced to question our expectations of the situation. We ask: Why? What for? How do I do it? And so on. These events occur more frequently than optimal experiences; they are common to everyday living whereas flow happens from time to time. A moment in time constitutes the time of an event and it is in this that we experience the situation.

My own model of learning is based on this idea that we learn from events such as this and that episodes are series of events bound together in a continuing awareness, hence in Figure 2.2 I show the start of the next learning cycle. It is important to recognise that awareness spans time and that we learn to live within the flow of time but learning occurs as joined up series of events upon which we concentrate.

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Understanding the disjuncture created by the event is important in seeking to grasp the beginning of learning processes: we become aware that we do not know and that we need to know if we are to continue in either doing what we were doing or thinking what we were thinking. We have to re-establish that harmony through learning. Children go through this period early in their lives when they are continually confronted with phenomena that they do not understand: Why this? And why that? All parents are aware of this stage of cognitive development – children need answers so that they can feel at home in their world, parents and significant others provide those answers and we all become part of our culture, or subculture. We all experience this disjuncture when we enter different cultures and subcultures.

As Donald (2001) shows, it is the single event, which is much easier to capture in laboratory experiments, that has formed the basis of certain forms of research and which is even the basis of the conjectures of those scholars who think that most of our learning is hard-wired into our brains. However, an episode is much harder to capture in a laboratory experiment and so the longer time frame actually casts doubt upon the idea that we are hard-wired before birth and places much more focus on learning from continuing conscious experiences through which we construct our biography. Experiences are both single events and elongated episodes and we learn from both.

Part 4: Experience as expertise

An expert is one who ‘has extensive skill or knowledge in a particular field’ or someone who is ‘skilful or knowledgeable’ (*Collins English Dictionary*). Perhaps the dictionary should also have offered the possibility that an expert is both skilful and knowledgeable. More recently, Gardner (2007: 82), writing about the creating mind, suggests that:

> For every talented writer or composer who breaks new ground, however, hundreds are content – or resigned – to be ‘mere’ experts. An expert is an individual who, after a decade or more of training, has reached the pinnacle of practice in her chosen domain. The world depends on experts.

Although the world depends on experts, this is still a restricted definition, but nearly everybody is an expert in the art of living in society. Nevertheless, it would be true to say that for a number of years the word ‘expert’ has fallen into something like disrepute in some parts of the world as terms such as ‘competency’ have dominated the vocabulary of political correctness in both work and education. But we should not expect people to stop learning just because they have achieved the state of competence – it is a low expectation of achievement in social living, and this should not be an aim in education. We have all been witnesses to this growth of political correctness in UK that downplays the expert, who is better than others, and yet the sum total of every individual’s practice is their experience – their expertise – in this or that area of behaviour. We learn our expertise through experiencing and learning from the experience.

> One becomes an expert not simply by absorbing explicit knowledge of the type found in text-books, but through experience, that is, through repeated trials, ‘failing, succeeding, wasting time and effort … getting a feel for the problem, learning when to go by the book and when to break the rules’. Human experts gradually absorb ‘a repertory of working rules of thumb, or ‘heuristics’, that combined with book knowledge, make them expert practitioners.

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